

upgrading. The fact that not all such systems work properly doesn't deter resellers who fix them, using parts from other PCs.

What's in it for you? The biggest factor here is the price. (See box, 'The Truth about hardware'). There exists a substantial market for such machines, especially in small towns and villages beyond Mumbai. According to Jitubhai, such users make do with old hardware such as 486 and Pentium PCs because, "they just want a computer that gets the work done". City buyers though, tend to be more discriminating, and settle for "nothing less than a Pentium II", generally with all the possible frills possible, with their budget.

The government's ongoing computerisation drive is another area where a lot of secondhand hardware finds a home, given the fact that there is a constant demand and that most schemes are cash strapped. Computers could perform such tasks as word processing, data entry and accounting effortlessly five years back. So it only stands to reason that five-year old legacy PCs should still be able to do so, just as competently today. Most offices still use PCs for the same purpose.

Going mobile

Not only does secondhand mean 'for less money', it also mean 'more for the same money'. Enter secondhand laptops. Typically, laptops cost upwards of Rs 45,000 since their components are smaller, lighter and consume less power. Vishal Sagar of Plug n Play Technologies, in Mumbai's Lamington Road, says that laptops have great 'real estate value'—you can fit it into places you could never fit a desktop, and take it and use it wherever needed. "A lot of people come to me asking for a Celeron or Pentium 4 desktop, and I converted them to Pentium III laptop users."

Vishal deals in laptops, including refurbished ones. "We take laptops that are in working condition, and we test them thoroughly. We take Pentium IIs and Pentium IIIs; generally secondhand Pentium 4s and Athlons are not available. AMD laptops are not very popular. We

identify a role (for the computer), and offer a solu-

tion. If portability is available at low cost, it makes economic sense for people who make sales presentations, etc. Laptops are mainly used for Internet access, accounting work and presentations, though you could even run Photoshop on a Pentium III. The idea is getting your work done with less—you don't need the best, and you don't need the fastest.

Though laptop prices vary depending on specifications and conditions, generally a Pentium II costs between Rs 28,000 and Rs 35,000. He showed us a Compaq Pentium II with a 300 MHz processor, 64 MB RAM and a 10 GB hard disk, priced at Rs 32,000. A Pentium III can set you back by anything between Rs 38,000 and Rs 43,000. One common misconception is that you cannot upgrade laptops or that you have nowhere to turn when things go wrong. Some things such as RAM can be upgraded and hard disks can be replaced. "You can start with a basic secondhand



Jitubhai Patel
Proprietor
J.S. Equipments

...The attitude is, when you get home a Ferrari, sell the Maruti...

laptop and add optional parts such as a CD-Writer, a LAN card, a bigger hard disk, more RAM and even WiFi, an Infrared port and Bluetooth. As far as CD-Writers go, you will be restricted to external writers as you may not get an internal writer that fits where your old drive used to."

After-sales service is not a problem either. "In most cases, authorised service centres will service your secondhand laptop just as willingly as they will a new laptop, but procuring replacement parts may cause delays. The largest problem is the LCD screen. An LCD cannot be repaired, so it must be replaced, at a cost of Rs 20,000. It may be better to buy another secondhand laptop at Rs 30,000." It's just easier to avoid buying with screen problems.

Buying smart

Before running out to a store, identify the primary role of your PC, which makes it easy to identify the kind that you should

Watch Out!

- Certain secondhand components are more likely to fail than others. Ensure that the hard drive is in good condition; bad sectors indicate an imminent drive failure.
- The motherboard should be also be checked.
- As far as CD-ROM drives go, avoid the Creative 52X since its failure rate is rather high.
- Also, ensure that the secondhand modem works before you buy one.

buy. The dealers we spoke to said that many people often walk in with just a vague idea of what they want, like, "I'm looking for a Pentium 4", and that certainly doesn't help!

Most of the reasonably modern computers in the secondhand market can surf the Internet, or run a spreadsheet application well enough. You may not be able to run the latest software, but if your work gets done with less, it scarcely matters.

Service, though, as far as secondhand desktops go, can be a tricky issue. The resellers we spoke to typically do not offer any hardware support beyond installation, and most don't provide any software support. So an Annual Maintenance Contract from a reputed maintenance company might make sense. Another common concern with older PCs, whether existing or being bought secondhand, is procuring the right device drivers. Everyone we spoke to dismissed the problem as trivial—thanks to the Internet. As you might imagine, without modem drivers you're doomed. Most devices have at least generic driver support in Windows XP, but don't run Windows XP unless you have a Pentium III with 128 MB RAM at the very least. Newer Linux distributions also feature good support for older devices. However, the latest distributions such as Red Hat Linux 9 have some steep hardware requirements for the GUI version.

Seeing them in action

Arvind Chandrasekar, an IT professional from Delhi, is the proud owner of an impressive collection of antique PCs that includes a Sinclair ZX Spectrum Plus with all of 48 KB of RAM, a BBC Micro Computer, a PC XT and an old 386. Over time, he's put these oldies to several uses. Until recently, Arvind's cable TV service provider used his ZX Spectrum to display the screening time of a movie on the local cable TV